Some magic items are **indistinguishable** from their nonmagical equivalents, others are **obviously magical**. Handling a magic item is enough to sense that it is extraordinary, but learning its properties is not automatic.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. The **Identify** spell is the fastest way to reveal an item's properties.
2. Otherwise, focus on the item during a **Short Rest**, in physical contact with it.
3. At the end of the rest, you learn its properties and how to use it, but **not any curse**.
4. A **potion** is an exception: a small taste is enough to know what it does.

Example: Aldric holds a ring during a Short Rest. At the end, he knows its powers and command words. He doesn't know the ring is cursed.

⚠ Cursed items:

- A magic item's description says whether it is **cursed**.
- Most identification methods, including the Short Rest, **do not reveal the curse**.
- Attunement to a cursed item **can't be ended voluntarily**. The curse must be broken first, for example with the **Remove Curse** spell.

⚠ Point of attention

The three ways to discover an item are: the **spell**, the **Short Rest**, and **trying out the item**. See also the **Identifying a Magic Item** sheet.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

No reliable way detects a curse before it takes effect, and players may distrust every item they find. Fix: the **DM seeds legends and clues** so a curse stays possible to suspect, without being certain.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

A curse should be a surprise to its bearer when it acts. It can torment its owner, sometimes long after they stopped using it.

Step 1 – Handle the item:

The character senses the item is extraordinary, without knowing its properties. Some items are discreet, others obviously magical.

Step 2 – Look for clues:

An item sometimes offers a clue: a ring's command word etched inside the band, or a leaf motif suggesting a Ring of the Fallen Leaf.

Step 3 – Identify the item:

- **Identify spell**: the fastest way. It reveals the item's properties and number of charges.
- **Short Rest**: focus on one item, in physical contact. You learn its properties and use, except its curse.
- **Potions**: a small taste is enough to know what they do.

Step 4 – Wear it or experiment:

Wearing or testing an item also gives leads.

Example: a character slips on a Ring of Swimming. The DM says: "Your movements feel strangely fluid." The player dives into the river, and the DM tells them they swim remarkably well.

Step 5 – Attune, if the item requires it:

- It takes a **Short Rest** focused on that item, in physical contact. It can't be the same rest used to identify it.
- You can be attuned to no more than **3 items** at a time.
- Without attunement, you only get the item's nonmagical benefits.

⚠ Cursed items: what to do?

- You can't voluntarily end attunement to a cursed item.
- The curse must be broken first: the **Remove Curse** spell or an equivalent effect.
- Once the curse is broken, attunement can end normally (a Short Rest focused on the item).

⚠ Example of a deceptive item: the Potion of Poison

Potion, Uncommon. This concoction looks, smells, and tastes like a Potion of Healing or another beneficial potion. It is actually poison masked by illusion magic. The **Identify** spell reveals its true nature. If you drink it, you take 4d6 Poison damage and must succeed on a DC 13 Constitution saving throw or have the Poisoned condition for 1 hour.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Telling if an effect is magical

The game text says whether an effect is magical. Effects from spells and magic items always are.

Permanent effects

A permanent magical effect can be dispelled, unless its description says otherwise.

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